Programming in Python for Friends and Relations—Part 16

Creating a Screencast

Create screencasts to demonstrate your products.

Screencasts are an increasingly common way of explaining software products—I probably prefer Turbogears to Django because of the 20-minute wiki screencast by Kevin Dangoor [*files.turbogears.org/video/20MinuteWiki2nd.mov*]. So, this month, let us create a movie. A programmed slide show has been chosen as a simple illustration. The ideas can be expanded to create effective and compelling screencasts. The same concept can transform your digital images into an exciting audio/video treat for your parents.

A movie is really a sequence of images displayed at a predefined rate. The images are synchronised with the soundtrack. A group of images along with the corresponding audio is regarded as a 'scene' in a movie. Independently created scenes can be pieced together to create the illusion of a longer movie.

Defining the screencast

In this tutorial, start with taking a sequence of screenshots you wish to elaborate on. Then write a script for each of the screenshots. The application—Festival or eSpeak—will be the 'actor' that converts the dialogue in the script into a voice. Each scene will comprise the screenshot being displayed for as long as it takes to speak the corresponding dialogue.

Create a set of screenshots for the product you wish to talk about in a directory, numbering them sequentially—for example, PhotoApp00.png, PhotoApp02.png, ... PhotoApp05.png.

You can either write the script in a separate text file for each screenshot or in a single file. In this tutorial, we will look at writing it in a single file—a header line followed by the script and a blank line for